

WATER AND BOG PLANTS

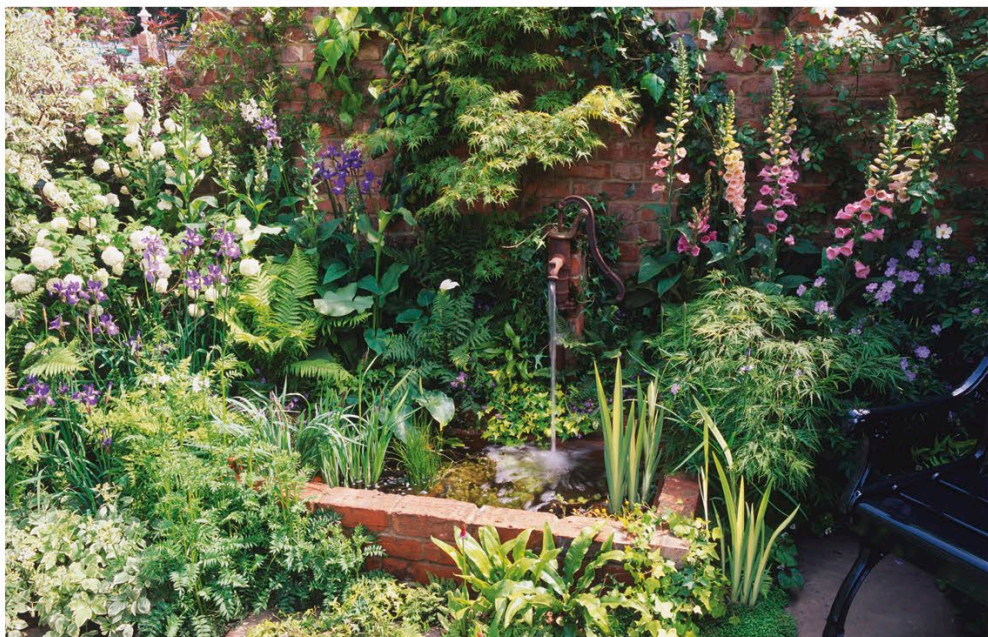
Still or moving water reflects light and adds a dynamic quality to garden designs. It also greatly extends the range of plants that you can grow, with aquatic and moisture-loving types injecting color, texture, and form into water features. They also provide an excellent wildlife habitat.

What are water plants?

The broad definition of water plants includes all plants that grow rooted, submerged, or floating in water. They are further subdivided into deep-water aquatics, surface- or free-floating plants, marginals, and bog or moisture-loving plants, depending on the depth of water they require.

Water plants are grown for their beauty and ornamental value, but when a wide range of plants are grown together, they also create a healthy ecosystem that maintains the quality of the water in a feature or pond. A balanced range of plants will regulate the levels of light, oxygen, and nutrients, helping keep the water clear.

Submerged plants like hornwort (*Ceratophyllum demersum*) are known as oxygenators. These purify the water by using up nutrients and excluding light, which prevents algal growth. Surface-floaters, such as water hyacinths (*Eichhornia crassipes*), also absorb dissolved nutrients. Deep-water plants, including water lilies (*Nymphaea*), root at the bottom of ponds, while their flowers and leaves shade the surface, again helping prevent the growth of algae. The roots of marginal plants are submerged, but their top growth is visible above the water, providing shelter for fish, amphibians and other wildlife.



Ornamental planting

To maximize your pond's planting potential, create areas at varying depths to accommodate different types. Begin planting at the center of your pond, using deep-water plants, such as Cape pondweed (*Aponogeton distachyos*) with its white flowers that pop up at the surface, and the floating water soldier (*Stratiotes aloides*), which has spiky leaves; both require a depth of about 24–36in (60–90cm). (See box

ABOVE Patio feature

Tiny but perfectly formed, this patio water feature, fringed by ferns, supports flowering irises and arum lilies. Flow from a pump helps oxygenate the water.

below for details on plant depths.) Most water lilies need to root at depths of 12–36in (30–100cm), depending on the species or cultivar. Dwarf water lilies, such as *Nymphaea tetragona*, or slender water irises (*Iris laevigata*) are good choices for

PLANTING DEPTHS

A pond with a range of planting depths allows you to grow a wide range of plants. Place plants at their appropriate depths, measured from the top of the soil in their containers to the water surface. Support young deep-water

aquatics on bricks and lower them to their final depth as they grow. Fill the pond a few days before planting to allow the water to reach the air temperature and become populated with beneficial microorganisms.

